OTHER TANKMEN OF WORLD WAR II

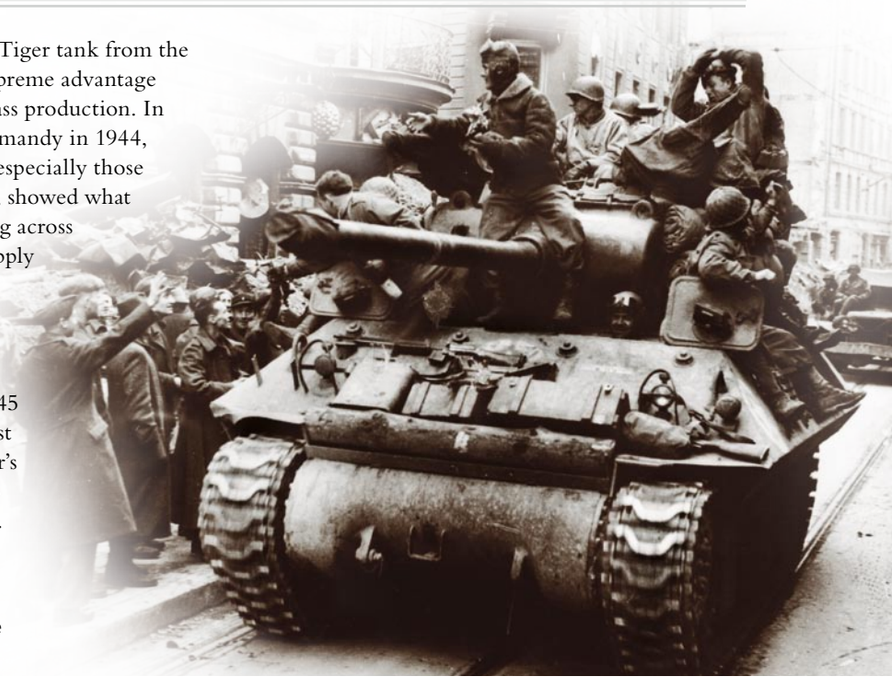
In 1940, tanks seemed to be the most glamorous of military vehicles. Nazi propagandists portrayed tankmen as modern-day knights, welding the latest technology to an aggressive warrior ethic. Yet the reality was often closer to the ironic British view of tank crews who "cheerfully went to war in tin cans, closely surrounded by a lethal mixture of petrol and ammunition". Early in the war, tanks promised a revolution in land warfare, allowing decisive victories to be won by shock effect and rapid manoeuvre. But by the end of 1942 attrition was back. Infantry learned to stand up to armour, while massed tanks fought one another in vast slogging matches. Mass production, rather than dash and flair, became the key to victory in a war that took a heavy toll of tank crews' lives.

US TANK CREWS

In the interwar years, US senior commanders viewed tanks as primarily an infantry support weapon. They were therefore fortunate in being able to watch the success of the German blitzkrieg in 1940 before themselves becoming committed to participation in World War II. The US 1st Armored Division was established in July of that year, and was soon followed by other divisions.

The US possessed an outstanding tank commander in the flamboyant General Patton, who did much to prepare US tank forces for their entry into combat in North Africa in 1942. Inevitably, it took the crews time to accustom themselves to real fighting, but by the time the invasion of Sicily was undertaken in 1943, Patton was able to lead his armour with verve, showing an instinctive understanding of the importance of maintaining the momentum of an attack.

The overwhelming majority of American armoured units were equipped with the Sherman tank, which was quick but inadequately armoured and was armed with a 75mm gun that could not damage a German Tiger tank from the front. But it had the supreme advantage of quantity through mass production. In the breakout from Normandy in 1944, American tank crews, especially those in Patton's Third Army, showed what they could do, sweeping across France full tilt until supply problems halted their progress. The swift reaction to the German counterattack at the Bulge in winter 1944–45 was another of the finest moments in US armour's notable contribution to the defeat of the Reich.



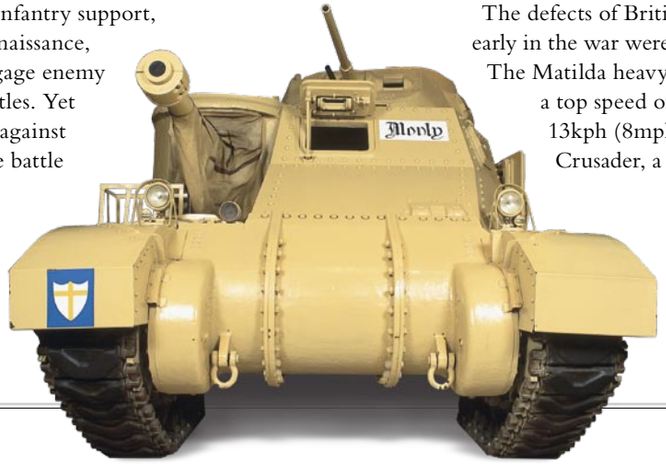
Fall of Munich
Tanks from General Patton's Third Army advance along the Dachauerstrasse in Munich to occupy the city in May 1945.

BRITISH TANK REGIMENT

The British invented the tank, but by the outbreak of World War II the Royal Tank Regiment had fallen behind the Germans in the development of armoured tactics. Britain had large slow tanks for infantry support, light tanks for reconnaissance, and "cruisers" to engage enemy tanks in running battles. Yet none of this worked against German forces in the battle of France in 1940. The 7th Armoured Division (the "Desert Rats") overwhelmed the Italians in Libya, but the arrival of the German Afrika Korps in 1941 soon put this success in perspective.

The defects of British tanks early in the war were manifold. The Matilda heavy tank had a top speed of only 13kph (8mph); the Crusader, a cruiser, was fast but thinly armoured, under-gunned, and unreliable. Tactically, the British had no answer to the German 88mm antitank guns, which they were often reduced to charging as disastrously as World War I infantry advancing against machine-guns. Later in the war the US-supplied Sherman and the British Cromwell were an improvement – but to the Germans all these tanks were "Tommy cookers" because of the frequency with which their crews roasted in flames.

Yet the British tankman never lacked grit and resolution. The tank crews drove Rommel out of Africa, slogged their way through Normandy, and had the satisfaction of ending the war in the heart of Germany. The Royal Tank Regiment lived up to its motto, "Fear Naught", and its men wore the regimental black beret with pride.



Desert warfare
The British Eighth Army made extensive use of US Grant and Lee tanks in North Africa. This Grant M3A3 was used by General Montgomery for forward observation.